



IELTS Listening Practice Test

Transcript — Parts 1–4 · Episode 9

PART 1

You will hear a woman named Sarah calling a sailing school instructor named James to book a weekend sailing course. You now have some time to look at questions 1 to 10.

Speaker B: Welcome to Blue Water Sailing School, this is James speaking. How can I help you today?

Speaker A: Hello James. My name is Sarah, and I'd like to book a weekend sailing course. I'm quite new to this, so I think I should start with the beginner course.

Speaker B: Hello Sarah! Yes, the beginner course is perfect for getting a solid foundation. We run those from Friday evening to Sunday afternoon. Now, we have a course starting on the 7th of May... wait, sorry, let me check our booking system again... ah, that session is actually full. The next available beginner course starts on the 14th of May. Would that date work for you?

Speaker A: Yes, the 14th of May is actually much better for me anyway. Let's go with that.

Speaker B: Perfect. Let me take down some of your details to reserve your place. What is your full name?

Speaker A: It's Sarah Harrison. That's spelled H-A-R-R-I-S-O-N.

Speaker B: Thank you, Sarah Harrison. And what is your mobile phone number?

Speaker A: It is 0-7-7-0-0-9-0-0-1-4-2.

Speaker B: Let me repeat that back to make sure I've written it down correctly:
0-7-7-0-0-9-0-0-1-4-2.

Speaker A: Yes, that's absolutely right.

Speaker B: Great. Have you done any water sports before, Sarah?

Speaker A: I haven't sailed a yacht before, but I've done quite a bit of kayaking over the last few years, so I'm comfortable being on the water.

Speaker B: Kayaking is excellent experience. It really helps with balance and understanding water movements. Now, about your stay during the weekend. We offer accommodation packages. There is a local hotel we partner with, or we have a hostel nearby.

Speaker A: Is there a hotel nearby? Actually, hold on, I should probably save some money for future lessons. Let's book the hostel instead.

Speaker B: No problem. I've noted that down. Do you have any dietary requirements we should pass on to the caterers for your lunches?

Speaker A: Yes, I am a vegetarian.

Speaker B: Noted. We have great vegetarian options. Now, the total price. The normal cost of the course and hostel accommodation is 280 pounds, but since you are booking more than a month in advance, you qualify for our early bird discount of 40 pounds. That brings the total cost to 240 pounds.

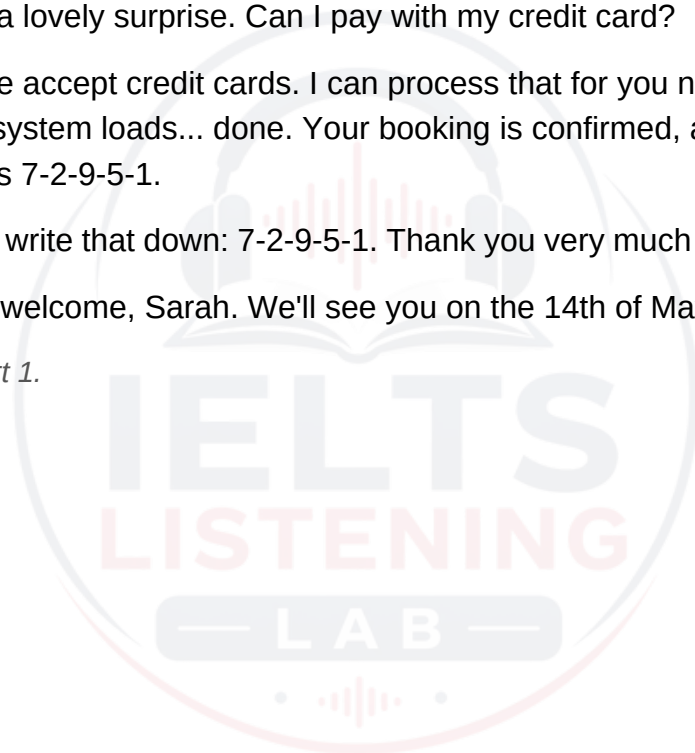
Speaker A: That's a lovely surprise. Can I pay with my credit card?

Speaker B: Yes, we accept credit cards. I can process that for you now. Just a moment while the payment system loads... done. Your booking is confirmed, and your unique booking reference is 7-2-9-5-1.

Speaker A: Let me write that down: 7-2-9-5-1. Thank you very much for your help, James!

Speaker B: You're welcome, Sarah. We'll see you on the 14th of May. Goodbye!

This is the end of Part 1.



PART 2

You will hear a talk by a community organizer named Helen about the redevelopment of the local park and garden. You now have some time to look at questions 11 to 20.

Speaker A: Good evening, everyone, and thank you for coming to this informational session on the Valley View Community Garden project. As you know, our town has long struggled with a lack of shared outdoor areas. When we first conceived this project two years ago, our primary motivation wasn't actually to grow organic vegetables, though that is a wonderful benefit. Nor was it simply to clean up the environment, although the old site was certainly an eyesore. Our true driving force was to bring neighbors together and foster a stronger sense of local community, creating a place where people of all generations can interact. We've certainly achieved that, with dozens of local residents joining us every weekend. Of course, running such a space requires funding. In the beginning, we received a generous one-off grant from a private charity, and the local council occasionally helps with waste disposal. However, we are proud to say that the vast majority of our ongoing maintenance and utility bills are covered by sponsorship from local businesses, who have been incredibly supportive. Now, some of you might be wondering how you can get involved. We are always looking for volunteers, and I want to emphasize that you do not need to have prior gardening experience. We provide all the guidance you'll need. Also, unlike many other volunteer groups, we do not require any minimum time commitment; you can simply turn up whenever you have a free hour. We also supply all the necessary tools and gloves, so you don't need to purchase or bring any equipment of your own. In addition to regular gardening, we host educational events. Next month, we are excited to offer a new workshop. While our previous sessions on building compost bins and identifying local insects were very popular, this upcoming workshop will focus specifically on how to propagate seeds. This is a crucial skill for anyone wanting to grow their own plants at home. Finally, don't forget to visit our small garden shop before you leave. While we hope to sell our own organic honey in the future, and we sometimes offer fresh herbal tea during special events, right now our main source of income at the shop comes from selling beautiful, freshly cut flowers grown right here in our greenhouse. Now, if you do decide to join us as a volunteer, we do have a few simple rules and guidelines to ensure everyone's safety and the smooth running of the garden. First and foremost, safety is our top priority. You must wear sturdy boots at all times on-site to protect your feet from sharp objects and heavy tools. Standard trainers or sandals are not permitted. Secondly, because we work outdoors in all seasons, we strongly advise you to check the weather forecast before you leave home, so you can dress appropriately for the day's conditions. Once you arrive at the garden, please make sure that the wooden gates are kept closed at all times. This is vital to keep out stray animals that might damage our crops. When you are working, please take care of our equipment. If you notice any broken tools, report



them immediately to the supervisor on duty so we can label them and prevent accidents. Finally, we want our volunteering sessions to be highly social. Every Saturday, our morning session ends with a shared lunch, which is generously provided by the project as a thank you for your hard work. It's a wonderful opportunity to relax and chat with your fellow gardeners.

This is the end of Part 2.



PART 3

You will hear two university students, Emma and Clara, discussing their research presentation with their tutor, Robert. You now have some time to look at questions 21 to 30.

Speaker A: Come in, Emma, Clara. Take a seat. How is your preparation going for next week's presentation on renewable energy?

Speaker B: Thanks, Robert. It's going well, but we've had to make some decisions. We decided to focus specifically on wave energy.

Speaker A: That's an interesting choice. What made you choose that instead of wind or solar power?

Speaker C: Well, initially, we thought about solar power, but there's already so much research out there, and we wanted something a bit different. When we looked into wave energy, we realized it's a relatively understudied area compared to others. There's less consensus on the best technology, which makes it exciting to analyze.

Speaker B: Yes, and while there is plenty of recent data on offshore wind, we found that wave energy has some fascinating engineering challenges that haven't been fully solved yet.

Speaker A: Excellent. And what would you say is the primary challenge facing wave energy devices today?

Speaker B: Many people think the main issue is that they are too expensive to manufacture, but with modern mass production, those costs are actually falling rapidly. Others worry about marine ecosystems, but recent studies show the environmental impact is minimal if they are placed correctly.

Speaker C: The real bottleneck is durability. These devices have to operate in incredibly harsh ocean conditions, with constant exposure to saltwater and powerful storms, and they struggle to withstand that kind of physical stress over long periods.

Speaker A: Quite true. Now, let's talk about the structure of your presentation. How are you going to hook the audience right at the start?

Speaker B: We thought about showing a short video clip of a wave generator in action, but we were worried about technical glitches with the projector.

Speaker C: Yes, and we also considered presenting a surprising statistic about global energy consumption. But in the end, we decided the best way to engage our classmates immediately is by asking the audience a question about their own energy use. It gets everyone thinking right away.

Speaker A: I agree, that's a very engaging technique. I've also had a look at your draft slides. They are very informative, but I think you need to make some adjustments.

Speaker B: Do you think we should change the background color scheme? We went with a dark blue, but maybe a lighter color would be easier to read?

Speaker A: No, the colors are fine. And your diagrams are exceptionally detailed and clear, so don't change those. My main concern is that you have too many paragraphs. You need to focus on reducing the amount of text on each slide so the audience listens to you rather than just reading.

Speaker C: That makes sense. We'll condense the bullet points.

Speaker A: Good. Is there anything else you need to finalize before next Tuesday?

Speaker B: We've already sorted out the division of speaking roles—Clara is doing the first half, and I'll do the second. And we've finished the summary slide at the end.

Speaker C: But we still need to print the handout for the students. We want to give them a brief summary sheet with key terms and references, so we need to get that copied at the library.

Speaker A: Excellent. Now, let's talk about the research sources you used. I'd like to get your thoughts on how useful they were. What about the academic journal article you referenced in your bibliography?

Speaker B: Oh, the one by Dr. Aris? That was extremely detailed, but honestly, it was far too technical for our needs. We struggled to understand the advanced mathematical models he used.

Speaker A: Yes, that journal is aimed at postgraduate engineers. What about the government white paper on renewable subsidies?

Speaker C: That was incredibly valuable. It gave us highly reliable, official figures on state funding, which really backed up our economic arguments.

Speaker A: Good. And the industry blog you mentioned?

Speaker B: We had mixed feelings about that. It had some interesting case studies, but when we checked the publication dates, we realized most of the posts were from ten years ago. So it was outdated but useful for historical context.

Speaker A: Yes, technology moves fast. What about the university textbook on fluid dynamics?



Speaker C: We actually found that to be too technical as well. It had hundreds of pages of formulas that weren't really relevant to our presentation's focus on commercial viability.

Speaker A: I see. And lastly, that documentary video on tidal barrages?

Speaker B: We loved that. Even though it was a few years old, it was highly reliable because it was produced by a leading scientific institution, and it explained the concepts in a very clear, accurate way.

Speaker A: Wonderful. It sounds like you've done some thorough research. I look forward to seeing the final presentation!

This is the end of Part 3.



PART 4

You will hear an academic lecture by a historian named William about the history and global impact of the nutmeg trade. You now have some time to look at questions 31 to 40.

Speaker A: Good morning, everyone. In today's lecture, we will explore the fascinating history of one of the world's most sought-after spices: nutmeg. Today, nutmeg is a common, inexpensive ingredient found in kitchen cupboards worldwide, but centuries ago, it was a highly prized commodity that sparked fierce international conflicts and shaped global trade networks. To understand its impact, we must first look at its origins. Nutmeg is derived from the seeds of the *Myristica fragrans*, a tropical evergreen tree. Historically, this tree was native to only a single, very small geographic area: the Banda Islands, a tiny volcanic archipelago located in what is now eastern Indonesia. Because these islands were the sole source of nutmeg, any nation that controlled them held a key to unimaginable wealth. During the Middle Ages, Arab traders kept the location of these islands a closely guarded secret. They transported nutmeg to Europe, where it became incredibly popular. European physicians believed the spice had powerful medicinal properties, and it was highly sought after as a cure for the plague, a devastating disease that regularly swept through the continent. Of course, with demand far outstripping supply, the price of nutmeg skyrocketed. Consequently, it was not just a culinary luxury or a medicine; it also became a major symbol of wealth and status among the European aristocracy. By the 17th century, European powers were determined to bypass the Arab traders and secure the source of nutmeg for themselves. The Dutch East India Company, in particular, sought to establish absolute dominance. They launched a series of brutal military campaigns in the Banda Islands to eliminate competition and create a complete monopoly over the production and export of the spice. This monopoly allowed the Dutch to control global supplies and keep prices artificially high. However, the British also managed to establish a small foothold on one of the Banda Islands, known as Run Island. This led to decades of tension and conflict between the two nations. The situation was finally resolved in 1667 with the signing of the Treaty of Breda. Under this historic agreement, the British traded their claim to Run Island in exchange for a Dutch-controlled territory in North America—a small, seemingly unimportant island known as Manhattan, which was then called New Amsterdam. At the time, the Dutch believed they had secured the far better deal, as the treaty solidified their total control over the global nutmeg trade, which in turn stabilized the global price of the spice and generated massive profits for their merchants. For over a century, the Dutch successfully guarded their secret. However, monopolies are rarely permanent. In the late 18th century, a Frenchman named Pierre Poivre managed to smuggle nutmeg plants out of the Banda Islands. He successfully cultivated them in Mauritius, a French island in the Indian Ocean. This broke the Dutch monopoly once and for all. Soon after, the British also began cultivating nutmeg in their

own tropical colonies. Most notably, they introduced the tree to the Caribbean island of Grenada, where the climate and volcanic soil proved to be ideal. Today, Grenada is so famous for its history of spice production that a stylized nutmeg fruit is proudly featured on its national flag. In modern times, the significance of nutmeg has shifted. While it remains a popular spice in global cuisine, scientists have also taken a keen interest in its chemical properties. Today, the compounds found in nutmeg oil are actively studied for their potential applications in medicine, particularly for their anti-inflammatory and antibacterial properties. In terms of global production, the landscape has also evolved. While Indonesia remains the largest global producer of nutmeg, exporting thousands of tons annually, a significant portion of the world's supply now comes from the Caribbean, ensuring that this historic spice continues to connect cultures across the globe.

This is the end of Part 4.

